> sedition they even mocked their neighbours, ‘Even your women’, they said, ‘do not belong to you.’[60]

In March 1840, Shah Shuja returned to Kabul from his winter quarters, and the court reassembled amid the pavilions of the Bala Hisar. With Dost Mohammad now immured within a Bukhara dungeon, Shah Shuja and his backers had a real opportunity to consolidate their joint rule. Instead the spring thaw saw the two rival administrations, British and Sadozai, beginning to compete with each other for control of the country. At the same time a growing realisation began to spread that it was Macnaghten, not Shuja, who was really running the new regime.

The cause of dissension was not a personality clash: Macnaghten remained as enamoured of the Shah as he had ever been. ‘My longer experience of His Majesty’s character more thoroughly convinces me that there is not an abler or a better man than himself in all his dominions,’ he wrote to Auckland on his return from Jalalabad.

> His Majesty sits in durbar every morning except Thursday for about two hours and listens with the greatest patience to the representations of his chiefs. One day is set apart for hearing the complaints of all those who may allege that they have not received redress from the authorities to whom their cases had been referred. Though stern in the execution of justice, as was exemplified only the other day in the case of the murderer for whose pardon much influence was exerted, yet His Majesty is merciful and kind hearted in the extreme, and if the personal qualities of a monarch could ensure popularity, Shah Shoojah could not fail to obtain it.[61]

There were however several issues of policy, as well as the simple realities of divided power which were now slowly coming to divide the Shah from his British backers. As Mohan Lal put it, ‘we neither took the reins of power in our own hands, nor did we give them in full measure into the hands of Shah Shuja ul-Mulk. Inwardly or secretly we interfered in all transactions, contrary to the terms of our engagement with the Shah; yet outwardly we wore the mask of neutrality.’ This annoyed Shuja and disappointed the people. ‘The Shah became jealous of our power, and of the influence which he thought we were daily gaining for our own benefit, contrary to treaty, and to suspect that all the people looked upon us as sovereigns of the land.’[62]

The first point of dissension was a growing disagreement over the army. Already aware of the massive cost of defending Afghanistan, and of the